

How does Anchee Min's allusions to poetry in her memoir, *Red Azalea*, reflect communist values?

Red Azalea, published in 1993 by Anchee Min is a memoir which contains a nonfiction narrative of the author's personal experiences during China's cultural revolution. The cultural revolution was a revolutionary but indoctrinating period of time led under Chairman Mao Zedong where he would denounce their past traditional and capitalist ideologies in China to convert into a communist nation. Thus, Anchee Min writes about her personal account during this revolutionary time, discussing the indoctrinating elements she's endured, her unique experiences in labor camps, as well as the fall of Mao Zedong. Anchee Min alludes to poetry in her memoir to undermine her experiences during the Cultural Revolution which emphasizes communist values towards Mao Zedong's ideology, sexual orientation, individuality, and society.

Through poetry written from Mao Zedong, Anchee Min intentionally provided Mao Zedong's communist ideology. Prior to the poem, one of the individuals in the labor camps irresponsibly planted the fields incorrectly and many of the upper division labor camp leaders critiqued everyone "for the careless planting" (Page 73, Anchee Min). Thus, Anchee Min takes incentive to fix Orchid's mistakes and then sings this poem,

"I've made up my mind

Not to fear death.

Overcoming all the difficulties,

I strive for victory.

I've made up my mind"

(Page 74, Anchee Min).

This poem highlights Mao Zedong's communist ideology which indoctrinated people like Anchee Min to be exploited in these labor camps. To not "fear death" creates an empowering tone for individuals during the cultural revolution, validating their overworked labor not as exploitation but for the greater good for the proletarian party. The repetition of "I've made up my mind" twice in the beginning and the end of the poem emphasizes the complicit behavior towards accepting Mao Zedong's communist ideology. Within the poem, it's intentionally explicit in which there's nothing challenging against the ideology but rather the only option is to accept communism. Individuals are indoctrinated to "overcoming all the difficulties" and "not to fear death", risking one's life for the greater good of the communist party. With this in mind, Anchee Min undermines her experiences within the cultural revolution through this poem to romanticize Mao Zedong's poetry and neglect the exploitation she has endured. Ultimately, there is an emphasis on adhering to a communist ideology while neglecting your own personal individuality because there is a nationalistic and patriotic purpose to provide resources towards the proletariat party. Thus, overall, the poem's purpose is to sacrifice yourself even to the point of death and be accepting towards the exploitation of your labor which benefits the communist party in China.

Additionally another poem written by Chairman Mao Zedong offers not only his communist ideology but also emphasizes a communist identity to indoctrinate society in order to showcase a representation of a "Model" communist civilian. "When one challenges heaven, it brings pleasure; when one challenges the earth, it brings pleasure; when one challenges one's own kind, it brings the biggest pleasure. He was reciting a poem by Mao. He was a true Communist would love to take challenges" (Page 39, Anchee Min). The poem has the repetition of "challenges" which acts as a hyperbole which over-exaggerates the power of a communist

identity. To challenge both “heaven” and “earth” in this case grows to work as figures of speech that indoctrinates people to believe in a divine power that arises from having a communist identity. Anchee Min undermines her experiences of the cultural revolution through this poem to highlight how individuality was only limited towards communism related aspects during this time period. Additionally, the tone of the passage chosen is very empowering, the word, “true” makes the reader believe that having a communist identity is chivious and righteous. Poetry made by Chairman Mao reflects his personal intrinsic values of communism. Anything that has Mao’s poetry and works of art has an implicit connection to communism especially during the Cultural revolution.

Exploitation in Communist China is a continuous theme throughout this memoir because it is integral to a communist identity during the cultural revolution. An individual that is symbolically westernized, Little Green, also has a poem which highlights a communist agenda. The song is My Motherland,

*There are girls like beautiful flowers,
Boys with strong bodies and open minds.
To build our new China,
We are happily working and sweating together*

(Page 63, Anchee Min)

The title of the song, “My Motherland” has a warm and positive connotation. It elicits a heartwarming and motherlike attitude towards the workers who are building the “new China”. These positive connotations highlight the indoctrinating elements during the cultural revolution and further showcase how integral labor was towards elevating the communist identity. This song alludes to the communist agenda of working together for one centralized government

towards equality as both girls and boys are explicitly referred to but despite their biological differences, both of their presences are important to building a communist state. Despite differences, everyone should be treated equally and therefore this justifies when everyone undergoes severe working living conditions at labor camps because no one is excluded from the exploitation that has to be endured. The transition from a Third person point of narration towards a Second person point of view with the word, “We”, develops a tone of integration and inclusivity towards a communist identity. This change in narration style helps develop a tone which allows exploitation to be diminished and ignored but rather is seen as a practical method of labor to progress a communist society. Anchee Min implements this poem, My Motherland, in remembrance of Little Green. Whilst Little Green was hospitalized, she was overdosed, gained weight, and her previous more western figure was gone. She was diagnosed with a nervous breakdown and looked unrecognizable. This placement of the poem also highlights Anchee Min’s nostalgia for Little Green prior to her being hospitalized and the poem helps recognize through a communist ideology, everyone should work together. However, Little Green is far beyond working together as she is depicted as mentally unstable so the poem Anchee Min uses helps develop an optimistic future where Little Green can work again in the Labor Camp, which is under communism.

Furthermore, the usage of poetry in the memoir can highlight skepticism that occurs whilst under a communist nation. This can be seen through the persecution of Anchee Min’s elementary school teacher, Autumn Leaves. The poem “A Wolf in a Sheep’s Skin” depicts the teacher as a wolf who is a secret spy trying to infiltrate and overthrow the Communist nation. “He said Autumn Leaves was the wolf. He told me that Autumn Leaves’ father was a Chinese American who was still living in America. Autumn Leaves was born and educated in America.

Secretary Chain said, The capitalist sent his daughter back to China to educate our children. Don't you see this as problematic?" (Page 29, Anchee Min). Anchee Min decides to place this biblical and poetic reference into her memoir because the poem reflects her dilemma with her teacher, Autumn Leaves. Through poetry, *A Wolf in Sheep's Skin*, it alludes to Min's feelings regarding her teacher. The persecution of the teacher was conflicting to Min because she learned from her and her teacher fostered grand knowledge. However, the parties' communist ideologies contrast the teacher's teachings when Min was chosen as the parties' spokesperson. The Story of the Wolf in Sheep Skin reflects the nature of communism and skepticism. In communist China, people are condemned if they have any bourgeois tendencies. In this case, a wolf is the "corrupt" values of capitalism that can metaphorically hide into a sheep's skin. Skepticism and paranoia reflects communism as people are paranoid to believe that even their neighbors might be spies against their nation.

In conclusion, the role of poems plays a big role in the memoir, *Red Azuela* because it showcases insight of communism during China's cultural revolution. However, since *Red Azuela* is a memoir, this is a limitation of the validity of Anchee Min's experiences during the cultural revolution. Her stories and experiences are her personal accounts that she has to recall by memory. Thus, some aspects of the memoir can be omitted, not explained enough, or might be over exaggerated. Nevertheless, this memoir is valuable because it showcases her unique experiences within labor camps, her experiences of sexual individuality, and also recalls the fall of Mao Zedong which can be a significant primary source to highlight both the rise as well as the fall of Mao Zedong during the cultural revolution.

Work Cited

Min, Anchee. *Red Azalea*. Knopf Doubleday Publishing Group, 2006.